



INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF RESEARCH AND STUDIES

Month/Year : April-June, 2026

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22108489>



RECEIVED
16-04-2026



ACCEPTED
28-04-2026



PUBLISHED
30-06-2026

SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING ON CONSUMER BUYING BEHAVIOUR, A STUDY WITH REFERENCE TO INSTAGRAM USERS.

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ABSTRACT:

The expansion of digital platforms has reshaped how consumers discover, evaluate, and purchase products, with Instagram-standing out as one of the most influential spaces for brand communication. This study investigates how marketing activities on Instagram affect the buying behaviour of its users. Rather than relying on traditional promotional methods, brands now use visually engaging posts, short videos, and influencer collaborations to connect with audiences in a more interactive and personalized manner. This study is about figuring out how things that companies do affect what people think about products and if they will buy them.

The study looks at what makes marketing on Instagram work like how products are shown if the people talking about them are trustworthy how people talk to each other and what others say about the products. We want to see how people react to ads that're fun to watch so they do-not get annoyed. We also want to know what people think when they decide to buy something like if they believe it if they can understand it and if it seems real. Marketing on Instagram is important because people see a lot of messages from companies and get suggestions, from the app. We want to know how this affects what people buy over time.

We did this research in a way to get the answers we needed. Primary data has collected through a questionnaire targeting active Instagram users from diverse age groups and backgrounds. Their responses helped in identifying behavioral patterns and preferences linked to online shopping decisions. Secondary information from academic sources and industry reports was also reviewed to support the analysis. The collected data was interpreted using simple analytical methods to draw meaningful conclusions.

Keywords: Social Media Marketing, Consumer Buying Behaviour, Digital Marketing, Online Consumer Behaviour, Purchase Decision Process

Introduction

In today's world social media is a part of our daily lives. Instagram has changed the way we talk to each other, buy things and decide what to buy. A lot of people use Instagram every day. It is one of the most popular social media platforms. Instagram is popular because it has a lot of pictures, videos and fun things like stories and live sessions. This makes it a great way for companies to talk to their customers in a way.

Companies use media to tell people about what they do, what they sell and what services they offer. They do this by making posts, running ads and talking to people on media. Social media is different from ways of marketing because people can respond to what companies say. People can write back, leave reviews and say what they think. Now people often look at what others are saying online before they buy something from a company like that on Instagram. Instagram is part of this because so many people use it every day to look at pictures and videos from companies and other people, on Instagram.

This study is about Instagram marketing strategies. How they affect what people think of products and whether they buy them. We want to understand how Instagram marketing works and how it influences people's purchasing patterns. We are looking how Instagram marketing strategies impact consumer perceptions & what people buy. Instagram marketing is a part of this study and we want to learn more, about it. It aims to explore the relationship between social media engagement and buying decisions, particularly among Instagram users, who are often exposed to targeted advertisements and curated brand content.

Background of the Study

The evolution of the internet and mobile technology has revolutionized the marketing landscape. People used to do marketing on television, radio and in newspapers. But now that social media is really popular, companies are focusing on marketing. This way they can talk to the people they want to sell to.

Instagram is an example of this. It started in 2010 as a way to share photos. Now it is a powerful tool for marketing. All kinds of businesses use Instagram to show who they are, what they sell and to talk to their customers. They can pay to have their posts shown to people who work with famous users, use hashtags to get found and the website will even help them get their posts to the right people.

The way people buy things has changed a lot too. Now people are really. They look at what is online to decide what to buy. If something looks good, seems real. A lot of people like it that really matters. Famous people on the internet and the people who make content also affect what people buy. They do this by being trustworthy and relatable to the people who follow them.

Instagram and other social-media platforms are really important, for marketing. Companies can use Instagram to build their brand and to sell things to people. It is a part of how people find out about products & decide what to buy.

Review of literature

The way people interact with brands and decide what to buy has changed a lot because of media marketing. This has become a deal in today's marketing world. Over the ten years researchers have studied how social media platforms affect what people buy and it's clear that social-media is really important in the digital economy.

When people think about buying something they go through a process. They look for information evaluate options make a purchase and then think about their decision based on their needs and preferences. Things like culture, social influences and personal feelings all play a role in this process. Now social media is a factor that affects how people behave when making purchases.

Researchers have found that social-media has changed marketing. It's no longer about companies talking to customers; customers are now actively involved in creating, sharing and giving feedback on content. This interactive part of media directly affects what people decide to buy and also makes them more aware of brands. Many people use media to find information about products read reviews and get recommendations before making a purchase.

One of the powerful aspects of social media marketing is electronic word-of-mouth. This includes reviews, ratings and testimonials from users. These are important because they help build trust and credibility. People tend to trust what their peers say more than ads and this greatly affects their decision to buy something.

There's also a lot of research on influencer marketing. Influencers are like opinion leaders who shape what people think and feel about brands. Studies show that when influencers endorse products it can increase brand awareness create connections and motivate people to buy—especially younger people.

In marketing old models like AIDA are being re-examined. Even though the basic ideas still apply social media has changed each part of the process. For example algorithms now grab people's attention interesting content keeps them interested peer validation makes them want something and easy online shopping options make it easy to buy.

Research also shows how targeted ads and personalized content affect what people buy. Social-media platforms use data to show people content that they're likely to engage with which can lead to conversions and stronger brand loyalty.

Studies found that younger people, like millennials and Gen Z are more affected by media marketing than older people. There's also a difference in how men and women react to marketing, which means companies need to tailor their strategies.

With the benefits there are some downsides. Much information, fake reviews and lack of trust in influencers can negatively affect what people decide to buy. Also relying much on social media can lead to impulsive buying, which raises questions about ethical marketing.

Importance of the Research

This research is important in real-world scenarios. It helps us understand marketing and consumer behavior on media like Instagram. This understanding helps us see how modern marketing is different, from marketing and how it affects what people buy. The findings can help companies, marketers and entrepreneurs create social media marketing plans. By understanding what affects what people buy, like content, influencers and brand engagement businesses can improve their campaigns. Tailor them to their target audiences preferences.

The study is also important for consumers. It shows how social media can affect what they buy. This can help consumers make choices. Overall the goal of this research is to connect marketing and consumer psychology on Instagram. It provides insights that're useful today. The study looks at Instagram. How it affects consumer buying-behavior. Instagram is a platform, in todays digital market. The study's conclusions can aid companies in making efficient use of Instagram.

Research Methodology of the study

The way we do a study and reach its goals is called research methodology. This includes how we pick the people we want to study how we get the information we need how we plan the study and what tools we use to look at the information. The goal of this study is to see how Instagram marketing affects the decisions people make when they buy things. We want to know how Instagram marketing affects consumer purchasing decisions.

Research Design

To see how Instagram marketing strategies affect what people buy this study looks at the connection between the two. The study uses an approach to understand what people like and do not like about marketing, on Instagram. This makes it easier to understand what people think and feel about the things they see on Instagram when it comes to marketing. The goal is to learn more about Instagram-marketing strategies and how they impact consumer purchasing behaviour on Instagram.

Type of Data

The study is based on both **primary & secondary data**:

- **Primary data** is collected directly from respondents through a structured questionnaire.
- **Secondary data** is gathered from sources such as journals, articles, books, and reliable online resources to support the theoretical framework of the study.

Data Collection Method

Primary data is collected using a **survey method**. A questionnaire is designed with close-ended questions to ensure ease of response and consistency in data collection. The questions focus on user behaviour, engagement level, influence of advertisements, and purchasing decisions related to Instagram usage.

Sampling Technique

The study uses a **non-probability convenience-sampling method**, where respondents are selected based on their accessibility & willingness to participate. This method is suitable due to time & resource constraints.

Sample Size

A sample of **50–100 Instagram users** is considered for the study. Respondents include individuals who actively-use Instagram and are exposed to marketing content on the platform.

Target Population

The target population consists of **Instagram users**, particularly young adults and students, as they represent significant portion of active users and are more likely to engage with social media marketing.

Tools for Data Analysis

The collected data is analyzed using basic statistical-tools such as:

- Percentage analysis
- Tables and charts (bar graphs, pie charts)
- Simple comparison methods

These tools help in interpreting the data and identifying trends and relationships between variables.

Limitations of the Research

- The study only looked at a group of people so it might not show what the whole population thinks.
- What people think is based on their opinions, which can be unfair.
- The study might not be very detailed because it was done in an amount of time.
- The study only looked at Instagram it did not compare it to social media platforms like Facebook or Twitter.

Research gap

We still have a lot to learn about how social media affects what people buy especially when it comes to Instagram.

One thing we are missing is a comparison of Instagram, to social media platforms.

Many studies have looked at media marketing in general but they have not focused on what makes Instagram different like its pictures, short videos and interactive features.

Instagram is special because it uses a lot of features, short videos and different types of content but not many studies have looked at how these things affect what people buy on Instagram.

Another thing we do not fully understand is how people interacting with media affects their buying decisions. We know that likes, comments and shares are important. We do not know exactly how they make people decide to buy something.

We need to look at how people interact with social media and how that makes them decide to buy things.

People have studied influencer marketing a lot. We still need to learn more about whether influencers are really trustworthy. A lot of studies have shown that influencers can be good for businesses. We do not know what happens when people start to doubt influencers because they are promoting too many things or not being honest.

Influencer marketing on Instagram is a deal and Instagram influencer marketing needs to be studied more to see if influencers are really authentic and credible.

We also do not know much about how personalized ads work on Instagram. We know that targeted ads can grab peoples attention. We do not know if they always make people trust a business more or if they can sometimes make people uncomfortable.

Personalized advertising on Instagram is a topic and personalized advertising on Instagram needs to be studied more to see if it always works well.

Another area that needs study is how different types of people use Instagram. A lot of studies have focused on people, especially students but we do not know as much about how older people or working professionals use Instagram.

Instagram users are diverse. Instagram user behavior needs to be studied more to see how different people use the platform.

Most studies have looked at media in general or in other countries but we need to know more about how people use Instagram in specific places. Peoples behavior can vary a lot depending on where they live and their culture so we need studies that focus on specific regions.

Social media marketing on Instagram is social media marketing on Instagram needs to be studied more to see how it affects people, in different parts of the world.

Research Problem

Rapid growth of social media platforms has significantly changed the way consumers interact with brands and make purchasing decisions. Instagram is an important platform where companies show off their products with nice pictures and videos and they also work with famous people to promote their stuff. Lots of businesses are putting money into Instagram to advertise. We still do not know for sure if this actually makes people buy things.

People see a lot of things on Instagram every day. Not everything makes them want to buy something. Things like how good the pictures and videos are, if they trust the people if they like and comment on posts and if the ads are just for them might make a difference.. We do not really know how much of a difference these things make.

Thus, the primary question we wish to address is how Instagram marketing influences consumer purchases and what influences users' decisions to buy or not. Our goal is to determine what influences people's purchasing decisions on Instagram.

The study's objectives

- To investigate how Instagram marketing affects consumers' purchasing decisions.
- To examine how visual content affects consumers' decisions to buy.
- To assess how influencer marketing affects consumer confidence and purchase intent.
- To investigate how brand perception is impacted by user engagement, likes, comments, and shares.
- To evaluate how well Instagram targeted ads influence consumers' intentions to make purchases.
- To comprehend the connection between consumer receptivity to marketing content and Instagram usage trends.

Examination of Social Media Marketing's Effect on Consumer Purchase Behaviour

Social media marketing has really changed how companies talk to customers & make them want to buy. Social-media sites like Facebook, YouTube and Instagram are not just for chatting; they are marketing tools where companies can make friends shape what people think and sell more.

Impact, on Consumer Awareness

media helps make people aware of brands. When consumers scroll through their feeds they see products through brand posts, influencer updates and ads. This keeps happening. Lets people interact, unlike old-style marketing. This means even small companies can quickly get known and reach lots of people.

Impact on Decision-Making Process

The consumer decision-making process—problem recognition, information search, evaluation, purchase, and post-purchase behavior—is heavily influenced by social media. When people want to buy something they often look at what other people think about it. They read reviews and comments online to help them make a decision. This way they feel more sure about what they're buying.

Influencer Marketing

Influencer marketing is important. People listen to influencers when they want to buy something. Influencers seem like people not like ads on TV. So people trust them more. When influencers say something is good people think it is authentic. They want to buy it, especially young people.

Customer Interaction on Social-Media

People talk to companies on social-media. media lets people talk to companies and companies talk to people. Companies can use comments, likes and messages to talk to their customers. This helps people trust companies. Want to buy from them.

Buying on Social Media

Social media makes people feel things and want to buy things right away. When there are sales or limited time offers people get excited. Buy things without thinking too much.

Targeting Specific People

Companies can target specific people. Social media is good for companies because they can show ads to people. They use information about person, like their age and what they like to show them ads that're relevant. This makes people more-likely to buy things.

Brand Familiarity and Trust

People like brands they know. When companies post things on social media people start to like them. When companies talk to their customers on media people feel like they know them and trust them. This makes people want to buy from them again.

Problems with Social-Media Marketing

Problems with social media marketing. media marketing is not all good. Sometimes companies do things like fake ads or too many promotions. This can make people not trust companies. Also there is much information, on social-media that people can get confused and do not know what to buy.

Research Questions

1. How does exposure to marketing content on Instagram influence consumer buying behaviour?
2. What role does visual content (images, reels, and stories) play in shaping purchase decisions of Instagram users?
3. To what extent do influencers and content creators affect consumer trust and buying intentions?
4. How do engagement factors such as likes, comments, and shares impact consumer-perception of brands?
5. Does targeted advertising on Instagram lead to higher purchase intention compared to non-targeted content?

Hypotheses

H1: There is a significant-relationship between Instagram marketing exposure & consumer buying behaviour.

H2: Visual content on Instagram has positive impact on consumers' purchase intentions.

H3: Influencer marketing on Instagram significantly affects consumer trust and buying decisions.

H4: Higher engagement levels (likes, comments, shares) are positively associated with favorable consumer perceptions of brands.

H5: Targeted advertisements on Instagram have a stronger influence on purchase intention than general promotional content.

H6: Increased time spent on Instagram is positively related to higher susceptibility to social media marketing influence.

Findings and Discussion

Findings

The present study examines the impact of Instagram marketing on consumer-buying behaviour and provides several meaningful insights based on the responses collected from Instagram users. **Findings**

Instagram is a part of peoples daily lives. Most people who use Instagram check it every day. Some people spend a lot of time on it. Between one to three hours per day. This means that Instagram is now a part of how people live their lives. As a result people see a lot of marketing stuff on Instagram like ads and sponsored posts. This can affect what people think and do.

People notice when they see ads on Instagram. The way Instagram shows ads in peoples feeds and stories is pretty cool it does not bother people. People like looking at videos and pictures on Instagram, the ones that are short and fun to watch. They think these are more interesting than plain text or static ads.

Instagram also helps people decide what to buy. Some people have bought things after seeing them on Instagram. This means that Instagram is good at making people aware of products and at making them want to buy things. It is easy to find out more about products and buy them on Instagram, which helps.

Influencer marketing is also very important. People trust what influencers say especially if they seem real and honest. Influencers show products in a way that makes people want to buy them. They make it seem like the product is something people can use in their lives. This helps people feel more confident when they are buying things.

When people like and comment on posts it makes the product seem popular and trustworthy. People are more likely to consider buying something if they see that other people like it. This is because people want to know what others think before they make a decision.

Ads that are personalized are also more effective. People are more interested in ads that're about things they like or have shown interest in before. These ads seem relevant to people so they are more likely to look at them and consider buying something.

However not everyone is affected by Instagram marketing in the way. Some people are more careful. Consider other factors like price and quality before making a decision. This means that while Instagram marketing is important it is not the thing that affects what people buy.

Managerial Interpretation

The results of this study are really useful to understand how people buy things on Instagram. A lot of people use Instagram so it can be a tool for marketing. Instagram is different from media because it lets brands and consumers talk to each other. This makes it work better for marketing.

People like looking at images and videos because they are more interesting and help them understand products better. Instagram is a way to show products in a way that people like. People are naturally drawn to things they can see like pictures and videos. Instagram is good at showing things in a way that catches peoples attention, which's why it works well for presenting goods. The thing that works well about Instagram is that it uses images and videos and people, like that. Helps them remember things.

Influencer marketing is also effective because people trust influencers. Find them relatable. People really listen to what influencers have to say because influencers share their experiences and opinions. Influencers make people feel like they are getting advice from someone they can trust. This is a change in the way companies do marketing. Now it is about personalized marketing. Personalized marketing is when companies try to make people feel like they are talking to them. This is a shift towards personalized marketing where influencers play a major role, in helping people make decisions about what to buy. Personalized marketing is becoming really popular. Influencers are a big part of it..

Conclusion

So Instagram marketing really affects what people decide to buy. The study showed that Instagram is a part of how people become aware of things what they think about things and what they choose to buy. Things like pictures and videos people promoting products and talking to people, on Instagram are all things that influence what people buy.

The study also found that ads that are tailored to people are more effective. They should be used carefully to avoid annoying people. Instagram marketing is not the factor that affects what people buy but it is an important one. Businesses should use Instagram marketing in combination with strategies to get the best results.

Recommendations for Businesses and Marketers

1. Creating high-quality visual content to attract peoples attention.
2. Collaborating with influencers who are credible and relatable.
3. Encouraging user engagement to build brand credibility.
4. Using targeted advertising effectively to reach the audience.
5. Maintaining transparency and trust, with consumers.
6. Understanding consumer preferences to design marketing strategies that meet their needs.
7. Combining traditional factors to influence purchase decisions.
8. Conducting research to better understand changing consumer behavior patterns.

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